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SOMETHING OLD//





SOMETHING NEW

MoMA's renovation reignites debates over privilege in fine arts

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The Flip

How justin elicker unseated new haven's incumbent mayor

BY **RABHYA MEHROTRA**

photos by **VIVEK SURI**



I MET SALLY ESPOCITO in Cedarhurst Cafe right off Orange Street. She wore a white and black striped turtleneck and had long silver hair and brown eyes that crinkled when she smiled. After introducing myself, I asked how long she's been in New Haven, and she chuckled. "A long time. I'm 70, and I've lived here for all but six years of my life."

Sally started her career as a teacher at Hillhouse High School in the Dixwell neighborhood, and then as a counselor at Nonnewaug High School in Woodbury, 25 miles out of the city. After ten years, she worked at City Hall's Disability Services Department, transitioned to Yale's Student Accessibility Services, and then worked as an Education Consultant at the State Education Resource Center. Five years ago, she retired.

Now, she and her partner are members of the Chatham Square Neighborhood Association, which hosts community events like an annual picnic. She's also on the management team for her policing district in Fair Haven, which meets monthly at the local library.

Sally would not have considered herself politically active, however, until this year. She had been excited to support Toni Harp back in 2013, when Harp's victory would have made her the city's first female mayor.

But as she perceived mayoral mismanagement in the past few years, her opinion of the administration started to sour. In August, for the first time, Sally went beyond merely voting. She canvassed for Justin Elicker, now mayor-elect, in her neighborhood. "If you notice a problem and you don't work to change it, you have no right to complain," she said.

She wasn't alone. Although Fair Haven had voted for Harp for the past three terms, the district was one of several majority-minority wards, among Dixwell and The Hill, that flipped to Elicker. Sally, among other voters in these neighborhoods, propelled the shift in New Haven's mayoral politics.

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The 2019 election felt like déjà vu. In 2013, John deStefano, who had been mayor for 20 years, announced he would not not seek re-election. His retirement made way for a contentious primary between three main candidates: Toni Harp; Henry Fernandez; and Justin Elicker, then Alder for the East Rock and Cedar Hill neighborhoods.

That year, Harp's was a household name thanks to her 20-year tenure in the state senate, where she served as co-chairwoman of the Joint Appropriations Committee. "Harp ensured that New Haven received fair funding in the state budget," Alex Taubes, a local attorney and longtime Harp supporter, said in an interview with *The Politic*. "She also fought for progressive causes, helping to raise the maximum age of juvenile court jurisdiction from 16 to 18."

Harp's popularity propelled her to victory in the primary. New Haven is a one-party city of Democrats, so the primary typically decides the election. 2013 was no exception.

Harp ran for mayor again in 2015 and 2017, winning both elections handily. During those six years, Elicker headed the New Haven Land Trust, a local non-profit. In an interview with *The Politic*, he reflected: "I gained management experience and ultimately helped turn around the financial situation [of the organization]. I was also able to meet residents across the city, and understand issues in different communities." In 2019, however, Elicker decided to run against now-incumbent Harp; this time, the results were very different. On September 10th, Elicker won 58.29 percent of the vote. But unlike 2013, the election wasn't over after the primary.

"It makes you wonder if they listen"

Fifteen days after the first vote, Harp decided to leave her name on the ballot as the Working Families Party's candidate but suspended her campaign. Shortly after, Taubes and Emma Jones, who was also an attorney and ran the Malik Organization, which advocates for police accountability, launched a campaign on her behalf. They organized a group of approximately 40 members over Facebook and called the group the People's Campaign for Toni Harp. "A groundswell of support rose [after Harp's loss]," Taubes said.

The People's Campaign successfully encouraged Harp to resume her campaign in October. Harp did not rehire campaign staffers, nor did she open an office; the People's Campaign, with the help of volunteers, organized all activities.

On November 10th, Elicker won the general election by a sound majority, with 69 percent of votes to Harp's 31 percent.

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Sally points to the cop at the counter. "He's our district manager," she said. "We like him a lot." A district manager, she explained, runs the

area's police force and is responsible for creating community ties and establishing trust. I turned my head, but the cop and his coffee were gone.

The main problem has been turnover: In the last eight years, Fair Haven has had ten district managers. Two years ago, the first woman was appointed and replaced within a month. Another manager lasted a week before she was moved to Newhallville.

New Haven's community policing program was established under Mayor deStefano, and has grown to be a nationally-recognized program. "I was working for the government in the '90s when they piloted the program, and it's quite different now," Sally sighs.

Turnover has hampered the program's potential. "Relationships are crucial, and can't happen as long as they keep changing [who's in] in the neighborhood," Sally said. She and her neighbors pushed for reform, meeting with police chiefs to ask for long term placement. They were repeatedly assured district managers would not leave, only to be disappointed.

"It makes you wonder if they listen," she told me. "Mayor Harp never seemed to have a clear vision of policing."

It's no surprise that Sally knows the police force by face and name: She's lived in Fair Haven for 26 years. "When I first moved here, we were the youngest family on the block…. Now we're the oldest," she laughs.

Fair Haven is a neighborhood in the east part of New Haven with a sizeable Latin American immigrant community. Its main street, Grand Avenue, boasts some of the best Latin bakeries in Connecticut. The central Bregamos Community Theater is one of many places that bring citizens together to celebrate diverse cultures, through events like its Día de los Muertos parade in early November.

The neighborhood is also home to political change: In the general election, Wards 14 and 15 flipped from Harp to Elicker. Perhaps because her community is so close, Sally explained her grievances with the Harp administration through stories about her family, friends, and neighbors.

Two long-term residents on her block faced foreclosure this past year, and the families were forced to move. "I'm still not used to seeing those homes empty," Sally shared. She attributed the foreclosures partly to Harp's controversial tax hike to 11 percent in 2018. "The tax wasn't the only reason, but it certainly pushed those families over the edge."

Taxes were a city-wide issue in this election. Many voters were unhappy with the tax increase, a fact that the Elicker campaign frequently highlighted. Taubes, defending Harp, responded: "This was a matter of state, not city, government. New Haven's budget was slashed, and [Harp] had no choice." Elicker, in contrast, proposed the "Blue Deal," a plan that encourages Yale to increase its annual contribution from 11 to 50 million.

Sally, over her cup of coffee, directed the conversation to a school building on Grand Avenue. Once used as a swing space for other schools during renovations, the building now lies vacant and frequently vandalized. She and other community members wanted to transform it into a youth center for the neighborhood's low-income children and teens.

That wasn't what Harp's City Hall wanted. "Their vision was to put in a developer who made high-end housing with rents of $2,500," Sally said. After many community meetings, the city withdrew the plan. But the building remains vacant.

Meanwhile, development is readily promoted in other areas of the city. One such example is the Winchester Lofts, a $60 million project to update a World War II-era arms factory into an apartment complex where residents are surrounded by "artisanal adventures." Single-bedroom apartments can go for $2,240 a month.

Jacob Malinowski, president of Yalies for Elicker, argued, "Toni Harp was an excellent public servant, but under her tenure, certain areas of the city were helped more than others. And it wasn't the places that needed it."

Throughout New Haven, overall housing costs have risen. The government's Affordable Housing Task Force announced in a 2019 report that the city needed 25,000 new housing units. Seventy percent of residents thought that the government's efforts were inadequate.

From knocking on doors, Elicker found that "housing and development rarely came up in 2013, whereas in 2019 every other voter mentioned it." His platform promoted inclusionary zoning laws, which, unlike the previous system, would require all new buildings to prove a certain amount of affordable housing, rather than negotiating affordable units on a case-by-case basis.

Meanwhile, Harp supporters cited rising housing prices as a product of her success, rather than her shortcomings. Taubes argued that Harp administration policies addressing violence and education issues made New Haven a more desirable place to live. "Elicker twisted this [illegible]

> ***"Elicker's proposed antidote? "My goal was to go everywhere, especially where I was least well known."***



"They're precisely the sort of people that at-risk kids need." She read about the Board of Education's infighting in the newspaper. "It was an embarrassment," she sighed.

While campaigning, Sally repeatedly heard from neighbors unhappy with the Board of Education—they felt that the Board cared more about politics than their children. "The fact that there were three superintendents in four years signifies a problem," agreed deStefano. The New Haven Independent reported that the most recent Superintendent, Dr. Carol Birks, was removed in early October after reports of covering up spending and firing.

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"Elicker isn't more progressive, he just looks more white," Taubes tells me. It is perhaps too cold and windy to be sitting on Cross Campus, but it's a place that's familiar to both of us. When he first moved to New Haven in 2012 for Yale Law School, Taubes had not considered himself to be politically involved, but soon was swept up in the 2013 mayoral election.

From the start, he admired Harp's campaign and long-standing service to New Haven. "It wasn't even a question which candidate was more qualified," he said. After witnessing what he perceived to be racist and sexist attacks against Harp, he decided to join her team as a debate coach. He saw similar issues this cycle, which in part prompted the founding of the People's Campaign.

"Elicker ran a racist campaign of effective character assassination against a public servant," said Taubes.

I asked him if he was referring to the claims of corruption that circulated in 2018, which accused Harp of providing lucrative contracts to city developers in exchange for support. "I won't even say the c-word," he responded. "These claims against Harp are offensive and certainly not true. Frankly, they're only allowed because Harp is a black woman."

Harp's then-campaign manager Ed Corey alleged outside interference. He accused Elicker of working with his wife, who is an assistant U.S. attorney, and Democratic Town Committee (DTC) Chair Vincent Mauro to push an FBI investigation of City Hall.

The Harp campaign claimed that they were exposing New Haven to the truth. They put up fliers comparing Elicker to Trump—two politicians who, in their eyes, were only electable because of their wealth and overconfidence.

Taubes explained how, days after the primary, Elicker spoke at a dinner party fundraiser, organized by Mauro, where tickets went for $1,000. However, the New Haven Independent reported that the fundraiser was for the local Democratic party, and none of the funds went to Elicker.

Harp's negative campaign tactics didn't resonate with voters like Sally. "I was particularly disturbed by the comparison to Trump. I didn't understand where they were coming from, and they seemed to be more divisive than productive," she said.

The Harp campaign also believed that New Haven political structures failed them. Typically, the Democratic party's endorsement is decided by the DTC convention, comprised of ward committee co-chairs. Harp had won the convention with 34 votes to Elicker's 16.

After Harp lost the primary, however, some Democrats flipped to support Elicker. "Local Democratic leaders stabbed Harp in the back," Taubes said.

Elicker tried not to engage with these attacks, but in one contentious debate, it proved impossible. He shared with the *Yale Daily News:* "I think it's time that we talk about issues and the direction this city is heading instead of making up lies and inaccuracies about the other candidates."

Elicker's proposed antidote? "My goal was to go everywhere, especially where I was least well known."

This wide outreach appealed to Sally. "His victory speaks to his commitment to creating relationships across the city. He spent a lot of time in Fair Haven and other wards where he flipped results."

Harp, too, tried to appeal to a diverse coalition of voters. The afternoon before the election, she made her way to Fair Haven to campaign at an apartment complex there, but it wasn't enough.

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"The best thing about Elicker is that he just listens," said Malinowski.

Sally finished her coffee. Throughout the campaign, as she canvassed strangers and talked to friends, all she heard was that people wanted a conversation.

"Ultimately," Elicker said, voters "wanted an accessible government. We'll work on deeper issues like job creation. But we'll also make sure we'll get sidewalks and speed bumps fixed." In other words: No issue is too small.

Elicker hopes to unite the city after the divisive election and plans to build his core team from all groups, regardless of how they voted or what neighborhood they're in. Of the three women leading his transition, Elicker appointed Sarah Miller, a Fair Haven resident, who is described by community members as a "fierce" advocate for her neighborhood.

Still, according to Sally, Elicker's work is not over: "He hasn't met everybody in Fair Haven yet, and I would encourage him to come back."



GREEN RUSH

CALIFORNIA'S BELATED EFFORT TO CREATE EQUITY IN THE CANNABIS INDUSTRY

BY **EUNICE PARK**

AT THE AGE OF 17, Daniel Montero began smoking and selling marijuana full-time in California. Even near-death encounters and two prison sentences for felony marijuana charges didn't dissuade him. "It's not just about getting high. It's a green renaissance."

Montero is a first-generation American and survivor of the war on drugs. But after California's recent legalization of marijuana in 2018 under the state's Proposition 64, his business is now illegal. Montero is now considered a "legacy operator"—a cannabis businessman with previous experience in the industry. He is an avid enthusiast of "cannabis culture," the chair of the San Jose Cannabis Equity Working Group, and a skilled community organizer in the rapidly expanding industry.

In the past year, businesses have invested millions of dollars into opening hundreds of marijuana shops in California's modern-day equivalent of a gold rush. The media has heralded legalization as a policy win for racial justice due to its radical departure from the former "tough on crime" drug policies that criminalized marijuana use. However, some fear this praise risks erasing the oppressive history of the war on drugs.

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Former U.S. president Richard Nixon is notorious for declaring this "war on drugs." As executive, Nixon created the U.S. Drug Enforcement Agency, responsible for tackling drug use and smuggling; dramatically increased federal drug agencies' presence in communities of color; and issued no-knock warrant policies, which give absolute authority for police officers to force entry.

President Ronald Reagan zealously upheld Nixon's anti-drug legacy by increasing mandatory minimum drug sentencing. Incarceration skyrocketed during his presidency, disproportionately for black people, the majority of whom were



"National Expungement Week 2019. Courtesy of Adam Vine and Cage-Free Cannabis"



nonviolent offenders.

Despite the lack of any scientific proof, marijuana was demonized as a highly addictive "Schedule 1 Drug," more dangerous than cocaine or fentanyl. Under the Clinton administration, Congress passed the Violent Crime Control and Law Enforcement Act of 1994, which dramatically increased prison funding and instituted a three-strikes rule: Anyone convicted of a violent crime who had two or more prior convictions, including drug crimes, was sentenced to life in prison.

California's law enforcement followed suit. From elected officials to school administrators, those in positions of power were similarly staunch in enforcing zero-tolerance drug policies. In the 1980s, Los Angeles Police Chief Daryl Gates intentionally targeted black and brown communities in drug raids and strongly advocated for harsher penalties. In a 1990 Senate Judiciary Committee hearing, Gates boldly testified that "casual drug users should be taken out and shot."

Between 2000 and 2010, a person was arrested for marijuana possession in the United States every 37 seconds. In total, eight million Americans have been incarcerated for marijuana-related crimes, with 88 percent of those incarcerations only related to possession. But as prisons remain overcrowded and the racialized consequences of the war on drugs become strikingly apparent, public sentiment toward marijuana use has shifted. Colorado was the first state to legalize recreational marijuana use. Ten additional states, including California, followed suit in years afterwards.

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Adam Bierman, CEO of MedMen, will tell you that he does not "run pot shops."

The assertion at first is startling: MedMen, one of the nation's leading legal marijuana dispensaries with over 36 physical stores, is an influential presence in seven out of the ten states with marijuana legalization.

It's all part of the goal. Bierman prides himself on destigmatizing marijuana—his strategy is to market to the untraditional demographics of "chardonnay moms" and "nine-to-five dads."

The moment you walk into a MedMen store, you're greeted with the luminescent glow of glass cases perfectly positioned on sleek tables. Alluring adjectives like "euphoric," "uplifted," and "elite" denote the effects of different marijuana strains. This Apple-store-like space, satisfyingly arranged with clean-cut, colorfully labeled marijuana strains, and gleaming vaporizers, seems worlds away from California's recent history of criminalization and harsh incarceration.

Political commentator and author Solomon Jones reminded readers of the ever-present effects of California's demonization of marijuana use in his *Philadelphia Inquirer* article: "Legalizing marijuana is the same kind of economic bait-and-switch that America has always pulled on people of color," he argued. "Blacks create an industry that has value—whether through legal or illegal means—and white folks change the rules, change the language, and change the perception in order to bring about a change in ownership."

This "economic bait-and-switch"

is glaringly visible in the current demographics of legal marijuana business ownership. In the most recent survey by *Marijuana Business Daily*, white people, like Bierman, own 81 percent of new marijuana businesses. In contrast, fewer than five percent of marijuana businesses in the United States were owned by black people. In a devastating irony, between 2000 and 2010, black people were 3.73 times more likely than white people to be arrested for marijuana, despite roughly equal usage rates.

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Historically, California's three major counties of Los Angeles, San Francisco, and Long Beach were home to a disproportionately high number of marijuana arrests. Today, these counties boast the highest concentrations of legal marijuana businesses.

These counties recognize their history, and their Departments of Cannabis have designated specific zip codes—"disproportionately impacted zones" based on past high rates of cannabis convictions — for social services. In these zones, more than 90 percent of residents are people of color and more than 80 percent are low-income.

Rarely do these residents participate in the new, legal economy.

Many prospective business owners have a criminal record, making it difficult for them to sign even a reasonably-priced lease. Although California recently passed AB 1793 to expunge marijuana criminal records, in many other states, felons are forbidden from attaining a retail marijuana license, even if their convictions are marijuana-related.

It costs at least a quarter of a million dollars to start a marijuana business, and there are no federal bank loans available. Prospective business owners must navigate the legal jargon of multiple permits and extensive building and facility inspections, which can quickly become expensive.

To counter this inequity, the three counties have instated "Cannabis Social Equity Programs" with the mission to "promote equitable ownership and employment opportunities in the cannabis industry, focused on those hit hardest by the War on Drugs." They offer public application workshops, priority applications, and fee waivers for licensing and business permits.

Los Angeles County's Department of Cannabis, assigns different benefits to individuals through a three-tiered system based on their length of residence in a disproportionately impacted zone and past record for marijuana-related crime. Tier 1, "equity," applicants access the most benefits, including licensing fee deferrals and access to a newly established "industry investment fund" to assist in startup costs.

All legal cannabis businesses in San Francisco must also provide a "community benefits agreement" policy in which they detail employment opportunities for those affected by the drug war. For example, Barbary Coast Dispensary, which provides public employment fairs in disproportionately impacted zones, is frequently co-sponsored by the San Francisco Department of Cannabis. In addition, the Department's staff recently toured the San Quentin State Prison to discuss thought-

ful drug policy with inmates.

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Now that California has legalized recreational marijuana, the trajectory of the industry's influence and growth in the state is unclear. In an interview with *The Politic,* Angie Maina, Program Specialist of the Long Beach Department of Cannabis, described this uncertainty as the "most difficult part of the [department's] job."

Social Equity LA is a non-profit organization that hosts bilingual Spanish and English workshops to provide legal and technical assistance for potential marijuana business owners. In an interview with *The Politic*, co-founders Adriana Gomez and Luiz Rivera detailed the challenge Maina acknowledged. Their organization has facilitated one-on-one training for applying for licenses, making sure that their "boots were on the ground, [by] holding candidates' hands and making sure that they were not left behind." Gomez stressed the reality that "making policy does not necessarily mean people have access to it."

As other states consider legalizing marijuana, many look to California's attempt at reconciling the history of the war on drugs with profitable, safe, and accessible marijuana businesses. "As we move forward with legalization, we need to start from the bottom up," Gomez reflects. "How are our communities of color being left behind? We need to make sure that in ten years we don't regret this."

Social Equity LA's mission for community investment is shared by Cage-Free Cannabis, another Los Angeles-based organization focused on social responsibility in the cannabis industry. In an interview with the The Politic, co-founder, Adam Vine, reflected on how incredibly nuanced the cannabis industry is and how it is "easy to lose sight of the humanity at the core of this issue." Cage-Free Cannabis has launched an annual "National Expungement Week" when they offer legal relief, voter registration, health screenings, employment workshops, and other services in addition to their usual work helping individuals expunge their criminal records.

Vine believes that the biggest challenge behind city-sponsored cannabis social equity programs is the lack of financial support from city and state government. Cage-Free Cannabis and similar organizations are "trying to fill in the gaps and provide the services that aspiring cannabis retailers need." Vine is excited for the growth of National Expungement Week: "You can expect to see the week continue to grow," he explained. "These people need legal relief and opportunities to enter the industry."

While the uncertainty of the legal marijuana industry can be a formidable obstacle, Maina acknowledged that "it has been rewarding to regulate a brand new and emerging industry, while thinking hard on how to connect with other cities and our own community for the best and most fair practices."

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"You often glorify the criminal lifestyle," Daniel Montero admitted. "But surviving bullets, robberies, parents being killed, families being killed…. It's a lot. It's not glorifying at all." Despite the cannabis industry's ambiguous future, some positive effects of marijuana legalization are

undeniably clear.

California's legalization of marijuana has been "so humanizing" for Montero because he's now able to openly promote the cannabis plant he "loves." But in California's efforts to regulate the new and highly profitable marijuana industry, Montero reminds us that "there is no point in building a mansion if the foundation is not correct." That foundation must exist in marijuana equity.

Marijuana equity is especially important when considering what Montero describes as marijuana's "tip of the iceberg" of opportunities. He notes the diverse uses of cannabis, some of which include effective pain treatment (CBD in the pharmaceutical industry) and sustainable building development (industrial hemp in the construction industry).

But the question of this equity in California's green renaissance still remains. As the chair of the San Jose Cannabis Equity Working Group, Montero advocates for permanent funding in cannabis equity programs. He recognizes that policies fail to matter if "there is no money to put it in play" and will continue "making sure the money generated [from the cannabis industry] is going to the right places."

Montero reminds us that building these businesses is not just about getting high, but rather about expanding opportunities for all communities. "I can die happy if I can continue this work. Equity is about giving opportunity to those of us disadvantaged by the war on drugs," he declared. "It's about our mothers, brothers, and sisters who've also suffered a domino effect from this war. Equity is to empower our people through cannabis."



"National Expungement Week 2019. Courtesy of Adam Vine and Cage-Free Cannabis"



IN A NAME

BY **IMAD RIZVI**

North Macedonia and Greece clash over historical and cultural legacies

GREEK PRIME MINISTER Kyriakos Mitsotakis lauded the new logo, released by the Greek Exporters Association at an event in November. The branding aims to promote local wine and foods produced in the northern region of the Mediterranean nation, but Mitsotakis sees more than that. The "GR" in "GReat" emphasizes the term "Macedonia" as Greek, which Greece claims should refer exclusively to the northern part of Greece, not the country immediately to the north.

The publicity campaign surfaced a year after the governments of Greece and its northern neighbor signed a deal to rename the latter "North Macedonia" rather than "Macedonia," the latest installment in a debate that has raged for over two decades.

"These poor Macedonians are being subjected to a great deal of pressure to basically find a new identity," explained Simon Zdraveski, a financier of Macedonian birth. "Basically,

whatever constitutes Macedonia is left to Greece."

Zdraveski, born in 1966 in a small village in modern-day North Macedonia, moved to Australia with his parents when he was five years old. He spoke only Macedonian at the time, and eventually became the first in his family to graduate from university—from the University of Melbourne in 1986—before pursuing a career in finance and tax advising.

Zdraveski married a woman of Italian descent. His children don't consider themselves Macedonian. He did not closely follow news from his home country. He hasn't lived in Macedonia for 48 years.

In 2018, after the controversial naming crisis with Greece, his relationship to the country changed

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"In one word, it was chaos," according to Naum Petreski. Petreski, a history student at Ss. Cyril and Methodius University in Skopje and a North Macedonian tour guide, was only a toddler at the time, but it has been recounted to him so many times he recalls it like it was his own memory.

In 1991, now-North Macedonia declared independence from Yugoslavia, backed by 96 percent of voters in a referendum. It was in that year that the residents named their nation "Macedonia."

The country's name immediately became a contentious subject. Although it celebrated its independence in 1991, Petreski explained, "the country did not become a UN member until April 1993 because of the name issue with Greece."

"The name issue" refers to Greece's efforts to prevent its neighbor from joining the United Nations under the name of "Macedonia." The term "Macedonia" has historically referred to the northern region of Greece, considered the birthplace of the Ancient Macedonian Empire. The Empire, ruled by Phillip II and eventually expanded from South Asia to Central Europe by his son, Alexander the Great, retains prominence in the cultural identity of many Greeks.

"The ruling Macedonians [at the time of the Empire] were mostly entirely Greek," noted Paul Cartledge, British historian and A.G. Leventis Professor of Greek Culture at the University of Cambridge. "Today's 'Republic of North Macedonia' occupies the territory occupied by the Paeonians in the time of Philip, who conquered them. The Paeonians were not Greek." Cartledge then explained how the region saw a migration of Slavic peoples southwards into the Balkans in the sixth century AD. Today, people in modern-day North Macedonia are an ethnically Slavic people with a Slavic language.

Consequently, Greece claimed the term "Macedonia" was solely Greek and refused to recognize its northern neighbor under that name. While Greece initially tried to block it from joining the UN, North Macedonia was able to become a member state in 1993 under the provisional name of FYROM (Former Yugoslav Republic of Macedonia). However, over 140 countries recognized the nation under its constitutional name of Macedonia, including the United States, Russia, and China.

"Greece is supposedly the home of democracy," Zdraveski despaired. "What kind of democracy are we dealing with here when [the majority of the United Nations] accepted Macedonia as Macedonia?" Greece continued to express its frustration against then-Macedonia with an 18-month blockade that they imposed in 1994 on the tiny, landlocked nation of two million people. To this day, many Greek citizens refer to the country as Skopje, the country's capital and largest city.

The 2018 deal, called the Prespa Agreement, put an end to the decades-long dispute that had seen Greece block North Macedonia's efforts to join the EU and NATO. The deal specified that residents of the tiny Balkan nation could refer to their ethnicity and language as "Macedonian," but their country name would have to be "North Macedonia." In exchange, Greece would offer its support in EU and NATO accession, as a single veto prevents any small European nation from joining the coveted organizations.

The tensions are far from over, though; the majority of both Greek and Macedonian citizens disapprove of the deal. On the surface, Greece and North Macedonia's naming controversy seems trivial, an inconsequential question of semantics. For millions of Greeks and Macedonians, however, it is a fight for history, culture, and identity.

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Robert Major waxes poetic about the history of Macedonia. "Macedonia as a name," he tells me, with a near-reminiscent air, "is

To Greeks today, the northern country's name—even with "North" in front of it—seems a blatant appropriation of their culture.

older than the Bible itself." Indeed, the name itself is a critical touchstone for self-titled ethnic Macedonians, many of whom feel they have been pushed around by stronger neighbors for centuries. Despite Greek claims to the term, ethnic Macedonians also boast historical ties. An official document from 1905 shows an immigrant by the name of Epta Naonmtche from modern-day North Macedonia. His documents list his nationality as "Macedonian" even though the region was under Turkish occupation.

Major moved from North Macedonia several years ago but still firmly identifies as Macedonian. "Does it matter where you live to know what is right and wrong? To know how you define yourself? Do you think that changing your living address can change your history? I don't."

Zdraveski expressed a similar connection to his birthplace, despite living thousands of miles away.

"This nation of mine, where I was born, is being basically systematically dissected," he grieved. "The last straw for me," he explained, "[is that the government] elected to eliminate the reference to our language within our school system over there." The Prespa agreement had promised to allow citizens in North Macedonia to still refer to their Slavic language as Macedonian. Zdraveski had heard otherwise.

"In America, you study 'English,' correct?" Zdraveski asked. "In Macedonia, students will no longer be studying 'Macedonian'; it will instead by labelled 'The Mother Tongue.'"

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Almost no country in the modern era has voluntarily renamed itself during a time of peace. Burma to Myanmar, Zaire to the Democratic Republic of the Congo (DRC), Khmer Republic to Cambodia—almost all involved violence and resulted from regime collapses.

In a way, North Macedonia's name change is not completely voluntary either.

North Macedonia has struggled economically ever since independence. The country was surrounded by political turmoil that seeped in during the 1990s and early 2000s, but even relative stability in the Balkans over the last decade didn't bring prosperity to the small nation. About a third of the population currently lives below the poverty line. The allure of opportunities that would come from joining the EU entices many Macedonians, though it remains to be seen whether European accession can solve many of the structural issues the country faces.

"This issue should've been addressed at the United Nations. N–not at some bilateral forum where Greeks basically have a gun to your head saying if you want to join the EU, you have to do this," lamented Zdraveski. Greece's veto would've been enough to indefinitely block accession to NATO and the EU, so a deal was required for entering these international bodies.

Many Macedonians feel not only pressured by their neighbor, but also betrayed by their own government as well. In the September 2018 referendum on the agreement, the people voted overwhelmingly to approve, at 95 percent. But the voter turnout was a measly 37 percent, below the necessary threshold to validate the results. Both sides claimed victory, though in the end it didn't matter. The government was able to push the resolution through Parliament regardless

of how the people felt.

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"I was there, and we were on the roads, yes," Maria Kaliambou recalled. Her office on the second floor of Luce Hall is filled with stacks of Greek books fittingworthy of a library collection. "It was kind of common in every school, the teacher and our fellow students went and protested that Alexander is ours. It's emotional."

Kaliambou, now a professor of Modern Greek at Yale, clearly remembers the 1990s protests when the Greek government and its citizens accelerated efforts to dispute their northern neighbor's name.

Protestors from all walks of Greek life and all political ideologies joined the popular chorus: "Macedonia is one and it is Greek."

George Mourgkos '22 grew up listening to stories of his mother's involvement in the protests. She always described the 1990s protests with a resigned air. Mourgkos recalled, "There were thousands of people protesting, and despite that, the government did nothing that was requested."

To Greeks today, the northern country's name—even with "North" in front of it—seems a blatant appropriation of their culture. Symbols such as Alexander the Great and the Vergina Sun hold an important place in the historical and cultural identities of many Greeks, especially in Greece's northern region. Cartledge explained: "The Macedonians of what became FYROM had called themselves 'Macedonians' since the late 19th century, but this was an appropriation of an originally Hellenic name." So in early 2018, when the Prespa Agreement was signed, over two-thirds of the Greek population was unsatisfied.

"My friends in Thessaloniki are angry," Kaliambou shared. "[Macedonians] usurped history for their own political purposes. This is not scholarship, this is not science, this is not logic. This is just propaganda."

Resignedly, she added: "I think we lost the name, the name is now for them."

Like in the 1990s, Greek protesters have taken to the streets. Thousands surrounded the country's Parliament—up to 100,000 on some days—and riot police responded with tear gas and flash bombs.

Mourgkos and his family thought about joining the activists. "My mom said that it would be futile for us to go protest," he told me. She was too disillusioned from the last time she had tried to speak up. "She had lost hope in the government

Many Macedonians today don't want to lay claim to Alexander the Great as an ethnic Macedonian—they simply want to embrace the word their family has used for generations.

listening to us."

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A few years back, Zdraveski took his family back to the village where he grew up. When he left in 1971, the village had not even 100 residents, and the majority of homes did not have electricity. Only one family remains in this village in 2015—distant cousins who reopened their home to him during his visit so he could show his six-year-old, eight-year-old, and ten-year-old sons where he spent his formative years.

In the last year, Alexander the Great Airport in Skopje has been renamed Skopje International Airport. The Macedonian Opera and Ballet became the National Opera and Ballet. Over 130 different state agency names in North Macedonia have been changed. Zdraveski was incensed: "They've basically eliminated any reference to Macedonia in all government institutions."

Although Cartledge and other Classical History scholars agree that Greece's claim to the term Macedonia is undeniable—by some reports, an over 2,500-year-old legacy—it is difficult for a country to lay exclusive claim to a history that was millenia ago. Contrary to Greek portrayals, the term Macedonia was not simply taken in the 1990s for the country to build a new identity from scratch: It has been used for at least over a century to refer to these Slavic people.

Many Macedonians today don't want to lay claim to Alexander the Great as an ethnic Macedonian—they simply want to embrace the word their family has used for generations. Petreski explained,"My ancestors used to identify with the name Macedonia, so I see it as cultural heritage and as a pillar of the national identity along with the language."

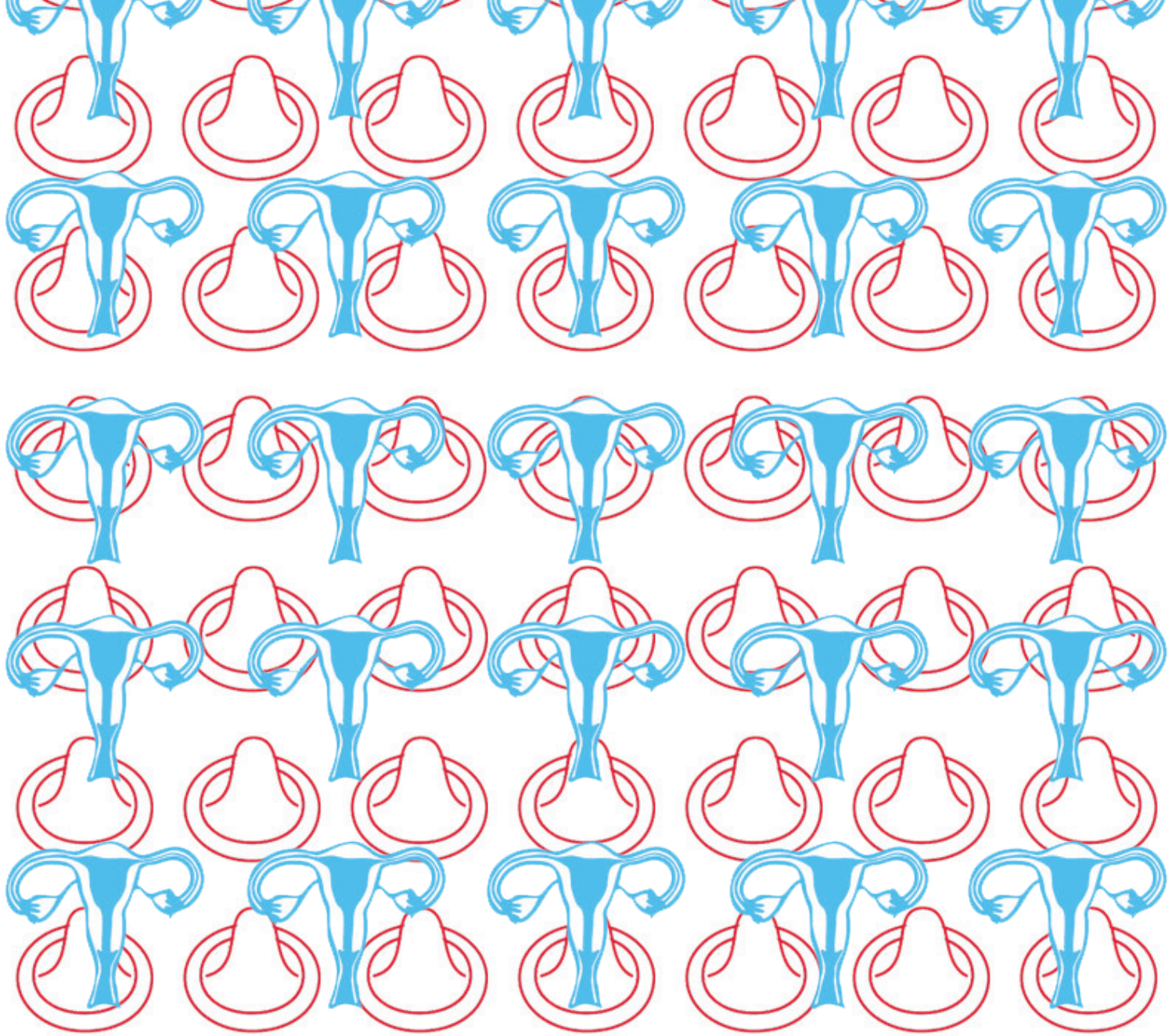
Greek people are not entirely unsympathetic to these claims. "There were many people who said the term Macedonia should not be in the name at all. I just thought that was a non-feasible thing to ask for," explained Mourgkos. Kaliambou agreed, adding, "Let's say you have a fellow sitting here born in North Macedonia raised with this mentality and this history in their books. How do you tell those kids and the younger generation that this is just an insane mistake?"

> **"How do you tell those kids and the younger generation that this is just an insane mistake?"**

For now, the future of North Macedonia and its relationship with Greece and the rest of Europe is largely unclear. Tensions between Greece and North Macedonia will likely continue over the next few months at the very least, as specificities from the deal are worked out and people in both countries will likely call themselves Macedonian for the near future. The EU issue is also still unsettled, as French President Emmanuel Macron blocked North Macedonia's accession in November.

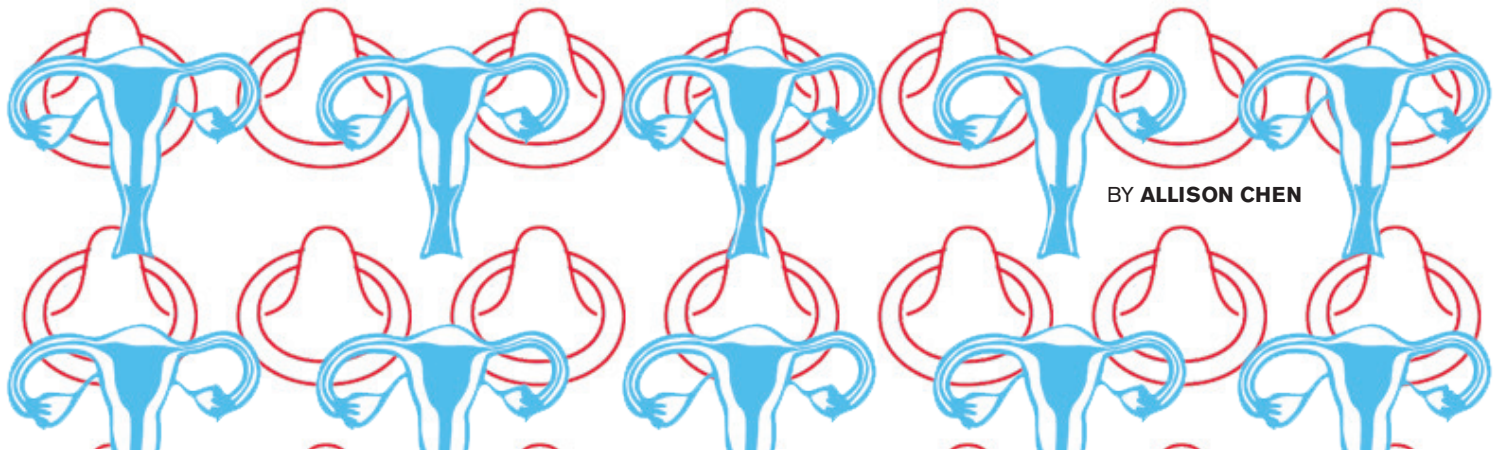
The Prespa Agreement promises that "nothing in this agreement is intended to denigrate in any way, or to alter or affect, the usage [of the word Macedonia] by the citizens of either party."

Regardless of what follows on both sides, this promise seems already to have failed.



SEX AND MYTH

Reckoning with rural China's haphazard sex education



BY **ALLISON CHEN**

XUPU, CHINA—PINZHENG Tang's teacher distributed "sex-ed" manuals—wedged between their math, history, and language textbooks—to him and his classmates on their first day of high school. On that sultry summer Hunan day, Tang regarded the manuals with mild curiosity, but they were never mentioned again.

"Rural schools won't have sex education classes," Tang, a 15-year-old student at rural Hunan's Xupu No. 1 Middle School, said in an interview with *The Politic*. "Unlike city schools, we need to spend all of class preparing for the *gaokao* [China's national college entrance exam]." To learn everything they must know, Tang and his classmates go to school from Monday to Saturday, with class from 7:50am to around 9pm each day. "We simply don't have time for sex ed."

He and his friends have never read the manual during the little free time they have, Tang said.

In December, China finished its first year of issuing certifications to sex educators. Until recently, the vast majority of Chinese adolescents had no formal sex education. In 2011, China's State Council made sexual health education mandatory in all schools, but most teachers taught abstinence-based education or biology-textbook sexual reproduction. In 2018, the Chinese government issued certifications to sex-ed lecturers, and these lecturers have created pop-up sex-ed camps, which some have attended in response to schools' lack of comprehensive sex-ed.

"It's still very conservative here," Yang Chen, a homeroom teacher at the rural Xupu No. 1 Middle School, said. "Sex education has not yet entered our classrooms with great fanfare."

Chen explains that if there were any sex education for students in rural Hunan, it would appear in a junior high biology class, if at all. As part of a series titled *Life and Health Common Knowledge*, Hunan students may receive "textbooks" that discuss a variety of health, safety, and hygiene tips. The content ranges from a biological explanation and diagram of male and female reproductive organs to advice for rescuing a drowning person. While some rural junior high schools dedicate class time to accompanying the "textbook," sex is mentioned briefly—one unit in a littany of many.The consequences of minimal sex-ed are visible. China, while 4.25 times as populous as the United States, performs 40 times the number of abortions–over 24 million abortions annually, compared to 600,000 per year in the U.S.. In 2011 to 2015, the number of HIV cases grew at 35 percent per year among the 15-24 age group, and China currently accounts for three percent of new HIV infections globally. Dangerous misconceptions unaddressed by teachers or parents contribute dramatically to these numbers. While students may receive more formal sex education in universities, many rural students never attend university, making sex education in secondary schooling even more critical.

"Chinese girls learn from their boyfriends. Their boyfriends learn from porn," Stephany Zoo, co-founder of Buzz and Bloom, an online service that provides sex health and education advice over Chinese messaging app WeChat, said in an interview with *The Politic*.

Zoo recalls one case in particular: One of her clients, a chemistry major at Tsinghua University, called her in a panic. The client's boyfriend told her that if a woman holds her breath while her partner ejaculates inside her, she will avoid pregnancy. Hold her breath she did, but she could not suppress a hiccup and immediately asked Zoo if the small intake of air had allowed

"TANG AND HIS CLASSMATES GO TO SCHOOL FROM MONDAY TO SATURDAY, WITH CLASS FROM 7:50AM TO AROUND 9PM EACH DAY. 'WE SIMPLY DON'T HAVE TIME FOR SEX ED.'"

"SEX IS A TABOO TOPIC IN CHINA. PEOPLE RARELY PUBLICLY DISCUSS SEX; THE 'BIRDS AND THE BEES' TALK FROM PARENT TO CHILD IS ALSO MUCH LESS COMMON THAN IN THE WEST."

her to become pregnant. Zoo knew the woman was smart— Tsinghua, dubbed "China's MIT," overtook MIT in 2015 as #1 on the U.S. News & World Report's list for best global universities for engineering.

"If [this client] could believe these urban myths," Zoo said. "You can imagine how many others in China might believe them."

Educational disparities are largely de jure. At birth, China's residents are officially assigned "rural" or "urban" *hukou*, a system of household registration according to place of birth. The designation on their passport limits citizens' mobility, and various *hukou* passports can offer wildly different privileges, including varying quality of education, housing, jobs, and more. While the schools for city-*hukou* students may offer some aspects of Western education, including access to new pop-up sex-ed workshops or experimental in-class sex education curriculum, rural students will be the last to receive these privileges.

Even then, the Chinese public, especially in rural, conservative areas, may be comfortable with only this small mention of sex education. In 2017, Beijing Normal University published a series of textbooks, titled *Love Your Life*, after over nine years of trials at select schools, but they quickly attracted controversy.

"There was big backlash," Darius Longarino, a Paul Tsai China Center senior fellow who has managed LGBT rights legal reform programs in China, said in an interview with *The Politic*. The controversial textbooks cover many sex and relationship topics, including homosexuality, reproduction, safer sex, sexual abuse.

The outrage began after one parent from Hangzhou—the cosmopolitan capital of Zhejiang province—posted pictures of the textbook to Weibo, China's Twitter, commenting on a "graphic illustration," in which a cartoon woman asks a man, "can you show me your penis?" The user added, "I myself would blush looking at it," which prompted some to denounce the textbooks as "absolutely unacceptable" and others to welcome them as a needed remedy to China's longstanding lack of sex education.

These textbooks, while lauded by Western media, have been slow to spread to less urban cities. In Tang's case, his entire sex education comprised the short snippets given in his junior high years. Even that was more than many other rural students receive.

Sex is a taboo topic in China. People rarely publicly discuss sex; the "birds and the bees" talk from parent to child is also much less common than in the West. But even if schools wanted to adopt more comprehensive sex education, school teachers—especially in rural China—may be ill-equipped to teach comprehensive sex education. Zoo explains that many teachers grew up during the Cultural Revolution, Mao's proletariat movement that also ruthlessly repressed erotic love to turn citizens' focus toward revolutionary communist ideals.

Wei Su, a former leader of the Tiananmen Square democracy movement and current Yale professor, lived through the government's sexual repression during his college years . As part of the first cohort to return to the universities since their doors were shuttered during the Cultural Revolution, Su remembers that even college

students were heavily discouraged from dating.

"There were no co-ed dances," Su said of his time at Sun Yat-sen University, which was founded by the first president of the Republic of China and the leader of the Kuomintang. "Everyone was too scared to organize one. Students who dated were sent to different cities after college."

Though Su organized the university's first co-ed dance in 1979, he got off easy with little punishment.

One professor nicknamed "Big Sister Ma," from Xi'an, a more conservative part of China, wrote an article encouraging women and men to have dances within their own homes. At the time, law enforcement found Ma guilty of mass "hooliganism, "a new criminal charge instituted by former Chinese paramount leader Deng Xiaoping for any "gangster behavior."

She was caught and promptly executed by shooting.

"It really scared people," Su said. "This was urban China, but rural China was even [stricter]." During the Cultural Revolution, "intellectual" youths were sent down to the countryside to learn from farmers and laborers. Those who later scored well on the *gaokao* could return to universities afterward. Those who did not remained.

Despite China's economic growth, the legacy of cultural conservatism survives, especially in the countryside. "They know nothing about sex education," Zoo said of most teachers. "It's blind leading the blind. Rather than getting giggles [from students], they give them a manual or a book and say 'go read it and figure it out yourself.'"

Even if the students read the manual, they aren't asking any questions, Chen said. "Students are embarrassed to ask anyways."

The cities are much more progressive, and Tang thinks that rural areas are still largely influenced by old Chinese morality. Similar to the American Midwest, some believe that teaching comprehensive sex education is akin to condoning sex and will encourage young people to have sex earlier. However, women in rural China typically marry earlier, become sexually active at a younger age, and thus become victims to various misunderstandings and ignorant attitudes about sex.

These misunderstandings are magnified on the countryside but exist everywhere in China. For instance, only ten percent of sexually active Chinese youths use condoms. While genuine ignorance factors into low usage, many have the misconception that only those who are "dirty" use condoms, Zoo said. They are commonly associated with prostitutes, which turns away some potential users.

Women are also reluctant to use birth control, due to a fear of seeming too sexually experienced. In fact, sexual ignorance in women is culturally attractive to Chinese men. Zoo also said that older women warned Zoo's clients that birth control would "impede on your womb and ability to get pregnant later."

This, combined with a wild litany of sexual superstitions—such as, period sex causes early menopause or sex standing up prevents pregnancy—has made abortion the primary form of birth control for many young women.

"It's hard to create discussion surrounding these types of issues," Longarino said. In combatting old, entrenched attitudes about sex, such as those surrounding LGBT issues or sex for pleasure, more awareness needs to be raised to change anything, he said.

After all, condoms are sold in many rural and urban grocery stores, often present at the checkout line with mints, magazines, and chocolates. An IUD costs less than ten dollars in China. Customers can buy birth control over the counter. But young people aren't using them enough.

Zoo was astonished when she talked to Chinese doctors about how rampant abortion was. Hospitals don't need to keep medical records of who has had an abortion. Zoo said that one doctor had a patient that already had five to six abortions, but the doctor didn't know it until they saw the patient's scarring. Before ending the one-child policy in 2016, the Chinese government had little incentive to remedy the high abortion rate.

Conversely, hospitals keep records of patients' STDs, which can worsen the consequences of lacking STD knowledge. In fact, having a record of an STD can be used against citizens for future schooling and employment, making them more easily transmitted and less adequately treated. For rural citizens who have less mobility, they are even more discouraged from coming forward with STDs, because of the increased lack of anonymity.

As a result, some government bodies, such as the Women's Federation of China have been supportive of increased sex-ed to help women understand their sexual rights.

Still, many question how necessary a more comprehensive sex education curriculum is.

"We grow up," Chen said. "That area of knowledge—we will just naturally understand."

Chinese citizens are becoming more sexually active; in 2015, 71 percent of survey respondents reported they had engaged in premarital sex, compared to 15 percent in 1989. As China undergoes a sexual awakening, it may need to prepare its citizens well.

Tang doesn't care whether or not he has better sex education at the moment. He and his friends just want to get into college, which requires doing well on one of the most notoriously difficult exams in the world.

"This one score will determine our futures, and a lot of us rural students might not get to college," Tang said. "We're not going to look at manuals in our free time if we're not taught it in class."

SOMETHING OLD//



"Tropical Fatigue and the Seven Wanderings: You Are Not Like Me" by Rina Banerjee

MoMA's renovation reignites debates over privilege in fine arts

BY **JULIA WU**

SOMETHING NEW



"A Stranger is in Our Paradise" by Rina Banerjee

IN THE ARCHIVES OF the Whitney Museum of American Art, Rina Banerjee flipped through the many binders that contained records of the museum's permanent collection, but couldn't find what she was looking for.

What she did find: Frank Moore's ink print of a stick figure holding a DNA strand, Mitch Epstein's photograph of a folded American flag in a dry cleaning bag, Conor McGrady's drawing of a man's shoulders with underwear over his head.

(She paused on the image of a decaying American flag, preserved in formaldehyde, curling around an upside down u-shaped glass tube. On the left side of the tube, the flag is a bloated swirl of red stripes. The right side is stuffed with the wrinkled white stars against blue. The piece, "Water Lilies #61," by Donald Lipski, engrossed Rina, a chemist-turned-artist herself, with itshis use of formaldehyde. For Rina, submerging the flag in this harsh chemical—conventionally used to preserve bodies—seemed like an attempt to preserve the colonial nationalism represented by the flag.)

What she did not find: art by women of color. "The book was almost 99 percent white and male," she recalled.

It was 2002, and Banerjee had been tasked with choosing a piece in the museum's permanent collection that resonated with her and creating her own work in response. The exhibit, "Five by Five: Contemporary Artists on Contemporary Art," was an honor, but Banerjee felt stuck as she considered her options.

She chose the Lipski piece. It was subversive, but she wanted to take it a step further.

Banerjee assembled a towering cascade of eclectic items. An open black umbrella hung from the ceiling, a turquoise lantern and home temple dangling from its handle. Underneath the mobile, feathered palm trees and small, toothpick American flags were planted densely in the topographical map of an island on the floor. There, two flies engaged in conversation. One remarks, "A Stranger is in Our Paradise," the name of Banerjee's piece. Banerjee renders the place of the flag—and thus



What she did not find: art by women of color. "The book was almost 99 percent white and male," she recalled.

America—as precarious, directly opposing Lipski's staunch conservation efforts.

The exhibit opened a year later. A New York Times review praised Banerjee's art for standing out among the pack, but there was another obvious distinction. Of the five artists featured, four were white and three were men. Banerjee's findings in the binder—works by a group overwhelmingly composed of white and male artists—were replicated in her own life. She was once again the only woman of color.

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The October 21st grand reopening of the Museum of Modern Art (MoMA) in New York City brought concerns like Banerjee's back into popular conversation.

The 40,000 square-foot expansion and other massive renovations reshaped the museum's entire approach towards exhibitions. MoMA opened new free galleries, studios for experimental programming, and creativity labs aimed at encouraging conversations with artists and visitors. It was a large-scale effort to reorganize existing collections so that "classics" like Vincent Van Gogh's "Starry Night" would be shown next to works by previously undiscovered artists.

Larry Kanter, Chief Curator of the Yale University Art Gallery and former Curator-in-Charge of the Met's Robert Lehman Collection, explained in an interview with *The Politic*: "The public interest in content of works of art and what lies behind them is not a new thing. It's been growing steadily over many decades, and now has reached a proportion where it's begun to play out in the public sphere."

Indeed, MoMA's latest effort fits in with its long standing philosophy. As an institution of modern art, it has always been radical compared to the old guard. MoMA was originally envisioned in the early 20th century by three female supporters of the arts: Lillie P. Bliss, Mary Quinn Sullivan, and Abby Aldrich Rockefeller. Throughout the century, they would display radical and otherwise-snubbed works of art like Marcel Duchamp's urinal-turned-"Fountain." The legacy continues: More recently, in response to Donald Trump's travel ban in 2017, curators showcased works by artists from Muslim-majority nations in protest. Banerjee's experience at the Whitney underscores the lack of diverse representation in the modern art world, even in progressive museums. According to Williams College, 85 percent of the works held by major American institutions are by white people and 87 percent by men. Only 3.3 percent of the female artists whose works were acquired by top museums in the past decade were African American.

Furthermore, museums have long been criticized as a leisure activity for the wealthy. Jennifer Reynolds-Kaye, Curator of Education and Academic Outreach of the Yale Center for British Art, explained,: "Museums are inherently a colonial institution, evolving out of the 'Cabinet of Curiosities,'" or *wunderkammern*—shows of "fine art and ethnographic objects from around the world through European eyes for European audiences."

The association between wealth and art grew exponentially at the end of the 20th century, when the rich began to treat art trade as an extension of the stock market. Works became about commerce rather than connoisseurship. With smart purchases of the right art, the wealthy grew richer and gained in social status. The embedded connection between class, affluence, and art in this period recalls power dynamics of the original *wunderkammern*.

In the past year, the International Council of Museums proposed an updated definition of museums that acknowledges the importance of inclusivity, critical dialogues, and diversity in exhibitions. However, Reynolds-Kaye explained, some in power in the museum world have not adapted their internal convictions to fit modern understandings. "The newer generation believes in people first, visitor first, the museum as a space for contestation and community building," Reynolds-Kaye observed. Not all

feel the same way.

The old guard's efforts are bolstered by the often-conservative preferences of donors. The boards of most major New York art museums are composed of less than 25 percent people of color. In an interview with *The Yale Politic*, Michael Shnayerson, author of *Boom: Mad Money, Mega Dealers, and the Rise of Contemporary Art*, emphasized museums' dependence on wealthy board members. "Museums often now can't afford to buy a hot young artist's work. They turn to their board members who are collectors and might buy paintings for them that then become part of the show."

Andrea K. Scott, an arts reporter for *The New Yorker*, wrote of the 2019 Whitney Biennial that art has become "a playground for the wealthy."

MoMA's recent five-month renovation represents the museum's attempt to recalibrate to the changing social context.

The museum's renovation seeks to create new dialogues between the viewer and the work, and between the works themselves.

Instead of giving the public more of the same, Kanter explaineds, MoMA, as one of many museums striving to "open-mindedly look at the nature of offerings they share with the public," wanted to "try something altogether new."

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The first time Banerjee's work was exhibited at MoMA was at the 2005 Greater New York show at their PS1 campus in Long Island City, Queens. At the exhibit, targeted at celebrating traditionally-unrecognized histories of New York art, Banerjee showed her sculpture "Tropical Fatigue and the Seven Wanderings: You Are Not Like Me." She remarked, "I'm still considered a foreign artist even though I've lived here all my life."

The sculpture is another waterfall of nostalgic items. The underwire skeleton of an umbrella hangs upside-down from the ceiling, its central metal rod attached to three old-fashioned, fading suitcases. The suitcases themselves are also inverted, tops hanging open, spilling their contents—a horn, eggs, banana leaves, feathered wings, glass beads—onto the gallery floor. A single lightbulb hangs between the bunches of fronds.

Banerjee's conviction of the need for inclusion in art was repeatedly reinforced through conversations with her male colleagues. She once attended the solo show of a female South Asian artist at the Guggenheim with an older male artist acquaintance. When she asked what he thought, he responded, "Well, the only reason that the show is here is because [the museum] is being charitable."

In 2017, Banerjee was showing at the Venice Biennale when the then-Minister of Culture of the Biennale said to her, "the only reason there are only 10 percent women in the [show] is because it is hard to find talented women."

At the same festival a year later, Banerjee was paired with another male artist for lodging and meals. She recalled that over dinner, "he talked about his work, invited me to his exhibition in L.A., and didn't ask me one question about my work, or anything."

On MoMA's renovation, she is not so optimistic. "There is a positive wish to expand MoMA's reach to include more women, but [specific curators] were not very open to artists from other places contributing."

There is a lot of work to be done, she explained. "The patriarchy within these museums is very stable and very blind…. They don't see your work as a contributor to the dialogue of art; they *do* see you as charity." Like other instances of incrementalism, "The inflation of visibility is a spectacle that deflects scrutiny of what is actually happening."

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MoMA's expansion appears on the surface to be a valiant effort at remedying its lack of representation. Indeed, in a press release, MoMA announced their intentions to use the extra room to acquire more works from artists of diverse backgrounds. Art by women now occupies some of the most



prominent positions in the museum. Sheila Hicks' monumental fiber sculpture confronts the visitor as soon as they step off the elevator. Betye Saar's "The Legends of 'Black Girl's Window'" was the featured show at the museum's reopening. Almost 30 percent of the artists on view in the new MoMA are women—five times the proportion in previous years.

In order to increase the number—and in theory, diversity—of artists the museum can highlight in their given space, MoMA plans on accelerating the turnover rate for exhibitions to every six months. Despite these efforts, it remains difficult for MoMA to balance increasing diversity and staying true to their collection. Kanter explained that in approaching this new mission, there remains "the risk that some museums are going to start collecting by quota."

The museum's staff plays an important role. Banerjee explained that curators need to be "interested in that project of connecting with the rest of the world, to realize that there is one human culture and we need to invest in that."

Beyond that, Gallerist Phillipa Feigen Malkin identified that quotas could be a dangerous model, because, "if you can't really find things that are beautiful or relevant by a female artist, but another work expresses the cultural context right now," then you sacrifice a museum's intended purpose by choosing the former.

Kanter calls this the pipeline problem: "The system doesn't have in its pipeline enough candidates from diverse backgrounds or with radically new ways of thinking to create a whole new generation of open-minded professionals."

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In 2018, the year before the remodel, Yugoslav artist Damjanski "hijacked" MoMA. In a guerilla art installation without the museum's initial permission, he used open-source augmented reality–which he called "MoMAR"–to overlay his own artwork over that of Jackson Pollock. "Museums are more of a one-way conversation," he explained, and this was his way to open a dialogue. MoMA seemed to agree: they did not interfere with his staging, and invited him to exclusive events.

The way Damjanski sees it, rather than expressing an "egoistic" concern over "giving away control by allowing other people to show stuff in [their] space," MoMA recognizes that he and his team are "always adding *on top* of their collection–always bringing more people into it."

Perhaps the most revolutionary change of the reopening lies in MoMA's reaffirmation of the democratization of consuming art.

The museum's promotional report for the renovation, *MoMA Now*, explains that exhibits are reorganized by theme, which "not only allows but encourages detours, digressions, skip-stops, shortcuts, and complete immersions, allowing each visitor to construct his or her own experience of the collection." The new paths encourage explorations into the tensions between each art piece, asking viewers to create radical new relationships between the works and themselves.

Furthermore, MoMA has introduced multiple free galleries. These are visible from the street through gargantuan glass windows, and are meant to encourage visits by people who are deterred by ticket prices.

"People you badly want to be [at the museum] can't afford to come," Kanter explained. "The thing is that we want [visitors] to be from all walks of life, not just from a select privileged background."

There seems to be the lingering danger that, even with free admissions, people of diverse backgrounds won't come. When asked about this concern, Kanter replied candidly, "You can't guarantee it, you just do the best that you can do…. All you want to do is remove the barriers. When the barriers are removed, it's up to the people whether or not they want to come in."

Kanter explained: "The more people who have access to museums, the more people might fall in love with art, and that to me is what matters the most…. Otherwise, why save it?"

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The MoMA redesign takes a first step in trying to answer the question Reynolds-Kaye at the Yale Center for British Art and other new-generation museum professionals are asking: "How do youw take something historically white and elite at its core and re-evaluate it?"

The museum's renovation seeks to create new dialogues between the viewer and the work, and between the works themselves.

Despite the renovations—or perhaps sparked by them—activists still express concern. At the reopening ceremony, protesters called for Larry Fink, Black Rock CEO and MoMA board member, to divest his company's holdings from private prisons.

While MoMA still has far to go in tackling its ingrained structures of exclusion—and in counteracting the exclusionary legacy of fine arts more generally—the museum seems to recognize its obligation. For one, MoMA will also be hosting more program collaborations with the African American art-focused Studio Museum in Harlem, an initiative that Banerjee praised. "These little steps to be taken are very important in terms of the message it sends," she said.

Despite some caution, Kanter expounded that "what MoMA did was an incredibly serious job with the highest of expectations met." Banerjee, though, sees the changes as a "standstill."

The success of MoMA's renovation in achieving its goals is in itself contingent on fostering healthy debate. After all, critics are doing exactly what the museum needs; they are engaging in conversation with its art.



photos by **VIVEK SURI**

TAKES A VILLAGE

New Haven food startup accelerators provide haven for refugees

BY **NEHA MIDDELA**

"WHAT WAS NEW HAVEN missing?"

Eduardo de Lara, a recent immigrant from the Dominican Republic, was living 25 minutes outside of the city center, in Orange, CT, when the question occurred to him in 2017. He had come to New Haven to visit friends and, walking down the street, realized what had been bugging him.

"Empanadas!" he answered emphatically.

De Lara moved to Connecticut three years ago, first to the town of Orange for a year, and after that into the heart of the city itself. At first, Connecticut didn't feel quite like home. When he grew up in the Dominican Republic, doughy empanadas were a constant, familiar presence—from his high school cafeteria to street corners to supermarkets. Once he came to the United States, however, he could find them only as appetizers in restaurants, and even then, they were served with unimaginative fillings that paled in comparison to the ones he was used to.

"They were only cheese or meat or chicken," he lamented, longing for more innovative creations. Moreover, most empanadas found in New Haven are Venezuelan -style, distinct from Caribbean empanadas in filling and in type of dough, yielding a flakier final product.

De Lara had no firsthand knowledge of making empanadas. He had never needed to: In his home country, they were ubiquitous and cheap. He remembers calling his grandmother for her empanada dough recipe, which did not prove to be helpful.

"Grandmas don't tend to have a measure of anything," he said wryly. "I tried looking for a recipe online, trying to make my own recipe myself."

He started to make empanadas in the traditional Dominican style, tailoring the recipe on weekends with his wife, who served as taste-tester and sous chef. De Lara added that even though his wife—originally from the United States—had never had an empanada before, she "fell in love" with the food, and now "eat[s] more empanadas than I do."

After mastering the technique, De Lara ventured into foreign territory, fusing traditional Dominican elements with flavors from other cultures. The results were as varied as they were delicious: Lasagna, strawberry, and chili-cheese empanadas soon brought De Lara's new company, Republic of Empanadas, to life. They were an instant hit at the Wooster Square Farmers' Market and in catering orders.

"This is what Sanctuary Kitchen brings to the community: a sense of belonging and family."

De Lara launched his business with the help of the Food Business Accelerator. A partnership between Collab New Haven and CitySeed, nonprofits that respectively support startups and food equity, the Accelerator provides resources for businesses run by women, immigrants, and people of color.

De Lara went through the Accelerator's 12-week, multi-stage program—one two-and-a-half hour seminar weekly, on topics ranging from "Investigating your Customer: Customer Discovery" to "Sourcing Food Locally, Wholesale Purchasing, and Farmer's Markets" to "Marketing 101 and Food Photography." Participants in the program are provided with a commercial kitchen, mentorship from an experienced New Haven food business owner, trainings for certification and food safety regulations, and the chance to sell their products at the CitySeed Farmers' Market. After the program concludes, the entrepreneurs compete in a culminating pitch day to win seed funding.

Caroline Tanbee-Smith, co-director of Collab New Haven, emphasized that the diversity of the entrepreneurs' lived experiences is a great strength to Collab's mission as an organization. She and her partner, Margaret Lee, always ask themselves: "How are we co-creating this vision with the entrepreneurs and their guidance and expertise?"

To bring diverse entrepreneurs to Collab, the program provides several services, including interpreters, childcare, and application materials in different languages.

Building a strong community within Collab and creating ties with the larger community of New Haven have both been driving forces within the program."It takes a village and a community to make this kind of thing possible," she said. To support its work, Collab has paired with other local institutions, including the City of New Haven, the Yale Law School, and the Connecticut Food Hub. The Elm City is a good fit for such an initiative, Tanbee-Smith explained. "New Haven has already invested so much in food and food culture."

Sumiya Khan, a co-founder and Kitchen Program Manager of Sanctuary Kitchen, echoed Tanbee-Smith's sentiment. Sanctuary Kitchen provides culinary training and employment opportunities for refugees in the Greater New Haven area with the ultimate aim of fostering meaningful, lasting connections between long-time New Haven residents and new community members.

"Guests that attend [our events] say that they are grateful for having the opportunity to meet someone who is a refugee or immigrant and hear their stories firsthand," Khan explained. She has witnessed New Haveners "opening their eyes to the reality of the conflicts that are going on and putting a face to the headlines."

Among the programs Sanctuary Kitchen provides, Khan highlighted the success of their cooking classes and supper clubs as ways to bridge cultural divides.

"At our annual fundraising event, Local Market, Global Table, there was an instance where the chefs were preparing the food, and they were all laughing and joking," Khan recalled. "A guest overheard the joy and laughter and said to me, 'This is what Sanctuary Kitchen brings to the community: a sense of belonging and family.'"

Khan emphasized the key principles of Sanctuary Kitchen: "We believe that food is a tool for social change. When you share a meal and share stories, you can create a welcoming, accepting, intimate space where genuine cultural exchange can occur."

The chefs at Sanctuary Kitchen hail from 11 different countries, including Syria, Afghanistan, Sudan, and Iraq. Khan recalled an instance when, as one of the chefs worked on a large catering order for grape leaves, all of the other chefs jumped in to help. "It was just a beautiful sight. They were sitting at the table, talking, chatting, rolling the grape leaves."

Carol Byer-Alcorace, the Sanctuary Kitchen culinary coordinator, highlights the way the program has helped refugees participate in everyday American life. "I've just seen their growth, in every way...speaking more English,

reading, talking, and taking ESL classes with joy."

On the other hand, De Lara testified to the garnish of Dominican culture he has brought to his new home country, and in particular was honored by the expansive base of Instagram followers he has attracted in the city. He shared several stories of families trying dessert empanadas for the first time: after walking off with their purchase, children immediately convince their parents to return for more.

He expressed his elation at sharing his favorite food with New Haveners, creating a "culture of empanadas" within the city.

In the past few weeks, the company's dishes at the weekly Wooster Square Farmers' Market have included seasonally-inspired empanadas, offering flavors like Pumpkin Spice Pie, Nutella and Banana, and Thanksgiving Turkey.



These successes in part come from Collab's unique model. Instead of measuring outcomes like most traditional accelerators—focusing primarily on metrics such as jobs created and revenue generated—Tanbee-Smith says their program has different considerations. Prioritizing the confidence of the entrepreneurs and the social connectedness between program participants has made the Food Business Accelerator both an effective program for new businesses, as well as a welcoming community.

Graduates of the program often occupy key roles on the Accelerator's board or serve as advisors. "A lot of these entrepreneurs, they're our friends, and we see them all the time," Tanbee-Smith said proudly. On one non-mandatory pitch workshop day, nearly all of the members of the cohort stayed after the end of the workshop to critique and assist each other. This experience, Tanbee-Smith realized, illustrated the "level of support, care, and earnestness" that participants show for each other.

"The goal of sharing is the *why*," Tanbee-Smith explained. "The best, most successful businesses know what they're doing and why they're doing it." She noted that this was especially important for women and people of color, who need to have "control over their own narrative…[instead of] the narrative having control over [them]."

Byer-Alcorace, who works directly with the chefs on a day-to-day basis, emphasizes that one of the most rewarding parts of her job is helping them tell the story of how their upbringings and experiences shape the food they create.

At a recent "Tea and Tradition" event hosted by Sanctuary Kitchen at the Creative Arts Workshop in New Haven, a squat white building with large windows and ample gallery space on Audubon Street, refugee women from various countries told stories of the role of tea and snacks in their lives. At the conclusion of the two-hour-long presentation, a man from the audience stood up, and said: "I'm sorry that you had to leave your homes, but I'm so glad you're here, sharing your experiences."

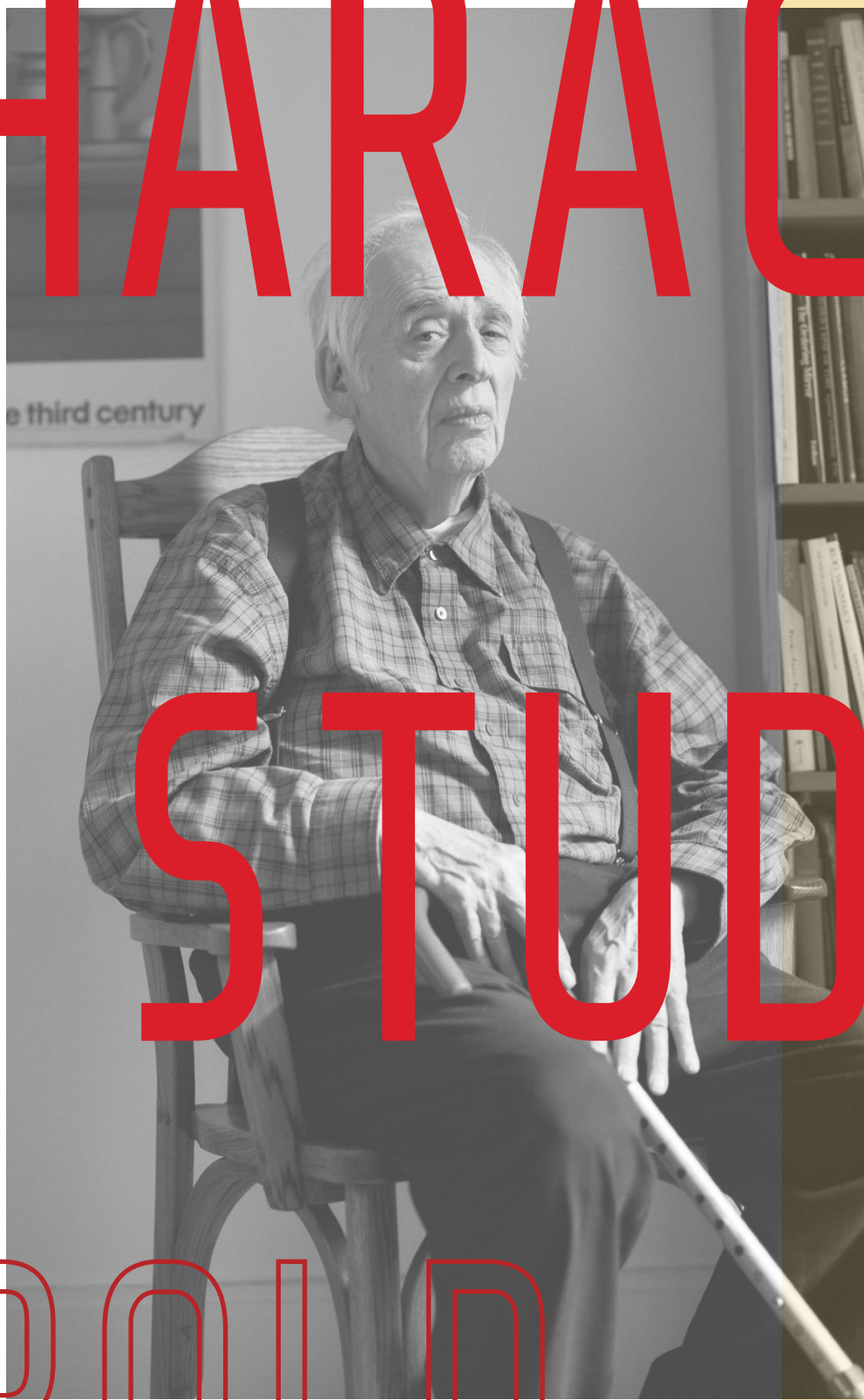
De Lara had no firsthand knowledge of making empanadas. He had never needed to: In his home country, they were ubiquitous and cheap.

De Lara, too, reflected on the joy of this community. His peers at the Food Business Accelerator are "incredible people; every time we see each other, we hug. You end there with new friends and family."

One day, with the help of his newfound family, he hopes to open a brick- and-mortar storefront—a permanent location in his new home.

"You never know what you can become."

CHARAC STUD HAROLD



Mark Mahaney for The New York Times

Reading and remembering Harold Bloom through his own literary lens

BY **EMILY TIAN**

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Jimmy Hatch reads the prologue of Harold Bloom's *How To Read and Why* every morning. Years before coming to Yale, while serving as a Navy SEAL, he brought Bloom's book *Genius* to the mountains of Afghanistan.

"I was reading it as a kind of translation for someone who didn't have a lot in the way of formal education, to get a grip or at least an idea of who was great, why they were great, what they did to become great, at least in the mind of this professor. The book was like another world for me. It took me out of the ugliness for a little bit."

Jimmy, an Eli Whitney student in his first year at Yale, speaks to me in the Whitney Humanities Center, minutes before we file into a Directed Studies lecture. His voice, full and rising from the stomach, slips into a reverential quietness.

"I emailed [Bloom]," Jimmy recalled. "I just said, 'Hey, thank you for writing this book. I'm in this really bad place in Afghanistan, [and this book has] been super helpful to me.' And he wrote back a few days later, one word: 'Survive.'"

Jimmy's story follows a fittingly poetic throughline: When he arrived at Yale, Professor Norma Thompson, Director of Undergraduate Studies for the Humanities major, introduced Jimmy to the influential literary critic.

They bonded immediately. "It's the first time the two of them have met and [Bloom] says to me, 'Now, Norma, I don't want any pushback, but Jimmy's going to take my class,'" Thompson described.

Bloom taught a Shakespeare course to Jimmy and his classmates—in his 65th year as a professor at Yale—until he passed away on October 14, 2019. It's rare for a literary critic to become a household name, but the flurry of obituaries and social media posts trailing his death suggest that Bloom's colossal oeuvre and outsized personality have been stamped into public consciousness. The great canon-shaper is near canonization himself.

However, Bloom's place in public memory is riddled with controversy. Critics of the Western canon accuse him of shortchanging women and writers of color while championing the white patriarchal elite. His legacy is dogged by allegations of sexual misconduct. The same fervor with which admirers exalt Bloom is echoed by those who criticize him.

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Bloom, born in 1930 to Orthodox Jewish garment workers in the Bronx, was a gluttonous reader. He described in a 1991 *Paris Review* interview skipping children's literature to read the American modernist poet Hart Crane in his early youth. Demurring when asked if he really could read 1,000

BLOOM

pages per hour, he scaled the number down to 400. He declared notoriously that "Shakespeare is God," such was his conviction that Shakespeare singularly reinvented the human condition.

After graduating from Cornell in 1951, he received a Ph.D. from Yale in 1955. He quickly collided with New Criticism, a mid-20th century American movement that approached each poem as a self-starting vehicle of close reading. Bloom, a passionate, flamboyant contrarian, resisted such formalist coolness. His early, ardent defense of Romanticism—returning Stevens, Shelley, and Blake to the aegis of academic scholarship—catapulted his meteoric rise at Yale. By the time he was 33, he was a tenured professor of English. In the 1970s, Bloom fell out with the department's Deconstructionists, who believed language and interpretation were unstable. Then-President Angelo Bartlett Giamatti tailored a new position in the Humanities department for Bloom as Sterling Professor, the highest academic rank at Yale.

Around this time, Bloom also developed one of his most important contributions to literary theory: in *The Anxiety of Influence*, he outlines how strong poets create original work despite writing in the shadow of their predecessors.

"What he did was to make literary history as compelling as, if not more compelling than, actual history. It wasn't a return to the old-fashioned biography of the poets. It was a new concern for what any figure read and how any poet reacted to what he did," Yale English Professor Leslie Brisman, who has taken over teaching Bloom's Shakespeare course, explained.

Although Sterling Professor of English David Bromwich insisted that his department would have welcomed Bloom back at any point, Bloom held onto his tenured title in the Humanities department for the rest of his career. From his lofty roost, he cut a rather lonely figure, balking against the plate shift towards socially and politically loaded literary interpretation, which he dismissively dubbed as the "School of Resentment."

Students piled into his classes. His immense physical presence underscored the voracity of an ever-consuming mind. A 1992 *Yale Daily News* article profiling Bloom described students making a bingo game out of his idiosyncrasies; no doubt his personality cult played a sizable role in making him such a campus fixture. For some, Bloom's superlative reputation made his classes frustrating. The article's author observed wryly that Bloom's seminar was dominated by one stream of thought—his.

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In the shadow of his magnetic personality and campus fame, however, rumors flew about his relationships with female students. *GQ* published a 1990 piece entitled "Bloom in Love" brimming with innuendo about Bloom's affairs. Four years later, Bloom's colleague and friend R.W. Lewis shared: "I hate to say it, but he rather bragged about [his wandering], so that wasn't very secret for a number of years."

The most explicit charge against Bloom came in 2004, when Naomi Wolf '83 published an exposé in *New York Magazine* accusing Bloom of sexual misconduct. She describes that Bloom, then her professor in an independent study course, invited himself over for dinner at her house, where he placed his hand on her thigh. In an interview with *The Politic*, Wolf described the 1983 encounter as "very, very traumatic."

After the article's publication, however, Bloom's reputation remained mostly intact, while a maelstrom of media coverage criticized Wolf's accusation. Headlines in 2004 spoofed on "crying wolf." Their implied question: That's all?

Some questioned if she embellished the story. Wolf has been frequently derided for exaggerations in her own writing. Her exposé was also published more than 20 years after the alleged assault, when the two-year statute of limitations for a criminal charge had long expired. Although she attempted to file formal grievances as recently as January of 2018, she claims that her attempts were stonewalled by the University. Still, she told *The Politic,* "It's my responsibility as a mom of young adults to get the truth to come to record."

Yale English professor Meghan O'Rourke was among those who publicly criticized Wolf's accusations. In a 2004 article for *Slate*, O'Rourke argued that Wolf was muddying the waters of sexual harassment discourse by presenting ill-defined evidence and making ungrounded assumptions about Yale's institutional response.

O'Rourke's opinions, however, have undergone a profound metamorphosis. In an interview with *The Politic*, she said, "When I read the piece now, I see what I felt but couldn't articulate to myself then: that is the struggle of someone who has been socialized to feel that it's very hard to

make these allegations, and to feel that therefore we had to present ourselves as hyper-rational when we did."

Yet when I asked Thompson about Wolf's accusations, she said, "It doesn't affect me in the slightest. Wolf has been accused of not being truthful in all sorts of her work, so I just bracket it.... We should be able to speak and to be heard. But I also teach the Salem witch trials, and I know what it means to just name a person and have that accusation taken as gospel truth."

Among the bevy of Bloom's correspondences the Beinecke Library has preserved, his letters to the poet John Hollander, whom he addressed as "Foofoo," bring to mind the lustful Bloom of rumors. Around 1965, in the early years of his teaching, Bloom wrote to Hollander, "I am trying to give up my major vices (lady graduate students, gluttony, sado-masochism, melancholy, paranoia) but it is not easy."

Such letters reveal the muddiness of stepping back into the past. For Bloom's time, such relationships, if consensual, were technically unprohibited. Only after an assistant math professor was found guilty of sexual harassment in 1996 did Yale begin to officially ban sexual relationships between professors and students. While ironically un-Bloomian, perhaps we can only understand Bloom by considering the historical moment he inhabited.

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I met Professor Brisman, once called Bloom's disciple, in his Saybrook College office, where snowdrifts of papers and Romantic poetry lie in vertiginous stacks.

In 1967, when Brisman was a Ph.D. student at Cornell, Bloom visited campus to deliver a seminar. Brisman was electrified—so inspired, in fact, that he promptly rewrote his dissertation on John Milton, which he had already defended. "He completely changed the kind of thinker I was," Brisman said.

There is still a cadre of Bloom loyalists at Yale. Thompson recounted, "Bloom was a man who collected people. He had so many friends. When [my husband] and I would be at his house on a Saturday or Sunday, somebody else would invariably drop in or the phone would ring and it would be such and such from somewhere else."

The renowned Yale professor's literary criticism comes out of a deep existential preoccupation: the bald truth of mortality—knowing we only have so much time to read—pushes forth the question of *what* we should read. As he writes in the introduction of *How to Read and Why,* "One of the uses of reading is to prepare ourselves for change, and the final change is alas universal."

To pare down a list of classics, Bloom had no patience for mediocrity. He did not bar writers of color or women from his canon ipso facto, but he rejected reading poems solely for historical or cultural import. Doing so, he believed, marred their aesthetic beauty. He read the great writers in dialogue with each other, never as history's first responders.

Not many writers have an invitation to Bloom's dinner party of greats, but that's all part of his plan. Does that sound aristocratic? Surely. But Bloom asserts a kind of selfishness and necessary loneliness to reading: we should not read for anything but the thing itself, nor for anyone but ourselves.

Yet despite his aesthetic idealism, he recognized the unpopularity of his position among many contemporaries. While he could be acerbic, impassioned, and exuberant with friends, he also slumped into a dinosaur-like melancholy, eclipsed by other strands of critical theory. He bemoaned the conflation of cultural criticism and literature. Marxist, feminist, postcolonial readings profaned the discipline he adored; they are not what literature is *for*. He envisioned himself as one of the last great defenders of his beloved canon.

At the same time, it's hard to tell when to take Bloom seriously. "He formulated [his criticisms] in extravagant ways deliberately," Bromwich recalled. Bloom was also known to impersonate his favorite Shakespeare character, the

Bloom's colossal oeuvre and colossalized personality have been stamped into public consciousness. The great canon-shaper is near canonization himself.

swinish knight Falstaff; one questions how much of his pedagogy was performance.

For many, his position belittled a legitimate concern about representation and meaning. However, although some of Bloom's students disagreed with his beliefs about inclusion and literary merit, those conversations rarely surfaced in class. By making his seminar a sanctuary for semi-monastic literary devotion (and respect for the giant man in the chair), Bloom enacted his scholarly idealism in the classroom.

"A lot of us...bracket[ed] off his class from other aspects of his work. But some of his popular writing's characterizations of what was happening in the academy in the '90s seemed wrong and troubling to me," O'Rourke observed. Nevertheless, O'Rourke found Bloom to be a generous and inspiring teacher. "It was an important class. It made literature feel vital and necessary.... It was like, 'Oh, actually, reading comes as a way of figuring out how to deal with the sense of imperilment that we all feel.'"

Steven Tian '20, who has taken two seminars with Bloom, became exuberant when talking about his late teacher. "He opened my eyes to a whole new universe," Tian said. Despite Bloom's academic stature, Tian describes Bloom as genuinely invested in his students' lives, helping them become "more full and complete human beings."

However, while Bloom's idiosyncrasy makes it difficult to imagine that the department will ever be the same, Thompson admitted, "That doesn't mean anything about how much influence he had in the university more broadly."

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A *New York Times* op-ed in October, after Toni Morrison's passing in August and Bloom's recent death, contemplated whether the canon wars have come to an end. Bloom's colleagues seem to agree that this chapter already turned somewhere in the fuzzy past.

In 2019, Bloom's position is increasingly difficult to defend. Two years ago, the Yale English department voted to revise the curriculum to include a comparative literature pathway in major. The former gateway courses to the English major, "Major English Poets," were renamed "Readings in English Poetry"—it is no longer in vogue to elevate an elite cadre of "major" poets. New methods of textual engagement also arrive from a different kind of literary scholar: those with multi-departmental ties whom Janis Jin '20, an English and Ethnicity, Race, & Migration (ER&M) major, describes as "hav[ing] a broader understanding of how we are supposed

photos by **VIVEK SURI**



Bloom is his most complicated character.

to read literature in the first place."

An op-ed in the conservative publication *Washington Examiner* lamented that Yale English students no longer have to study Shakespeare. It's superficially true: a student coyly evading the Bard could opt out of English 126 and play a game of hopscotch while fulfilling distributional period requirements. Although Bloom would agonize over these departmental transitions, the pace of change in the English department is still relatively glacial. In an interview with *The Politic*, English and ER&M major Irene Vázquez '21 quipped that she's taken as many English classes with white professors named Jill as she has with black women.

So where do the humanities at Yale go from here? The English department could buck its starched past, broadening the curricula and diversifying faculty hires. Expanding the writing concentration may be one avenue; Yale has traditionally been a house of critics, not creatives. One *Yale Daily News* article from 1994 lamented the departure of writers like Morrison, who became a tenured professor at Princeton. By contrast, if the English department truly were to lionize Bloom and his ilk, it could instead dig in its heels and vocally reaffirm its commitment to literature and the great books.

Jin suggested Bloom's pedagogical approach continues to influence the preponderance of close-reading in Yale's English department. "The difference between a lot of the core English classes and classes cross-listed or taught by an interdisciplinary scholar is the question of how much secondary scholarship you are reading," she said. Jin herself is more interested in "horizontal reading"—reading writers in conversation with contemporaries—than Bloom's temporal analysis of great poets in situ.

Vázquez, a poet herself, does not believe that reading the works of the Western canon is intrinsically wrong—she admits her love for William Wordsworth—but criticized Bloom's personal history. "Yale has the means to bring on a more diverse English department and not continue to hire an employee facing allegations of sexual misconduct," she said.

The loss of one of Yale's most iconic faculty members is an opportune moment for the University's self-interrogation. However, rather than asserting one direction or the other, Yale seems perfectly content floating in the uncommitted middle. Its relationship to Bloom seems ripe with contradictions: it has at once made a celebrity out of him—one suspects Bloom reached the apex of public fame for a literary critic—and shies away from fully embracing his breed of scholarship.

Even if the wider pathways to the English major provide one sign that the canon wars have ended, and even if cultural criticism and ethnic studies now occupy a more dominant position than in years past, Bloom's obsession with great books can't be historicized completely. For one, there are just far too many of his books and students. His canon is infused in high school curricula across the country, and his pupils have thoroughly suffused the academic world.

It's hard to neatly sever Bloom's intellectual work from the personal. His love of reading and teaching is startlingly vital and fundamentally humane. It's hard to engage in conversation about his flaws when many at Yale know him not only as an intellectual, but also as a warm and devoted friend. But if we exclusively apotheosize or criticize him, if we turn away from this task of simultaneous reckoning, then we haven't learned much from literature's own messiness. Bloom is his most complicated character. However we construct our interpretations, we must try our best to understand him. Isn't that the work he passes onto us, as readers?

A CONVERSATION WITH

On the "LOL, nothing matters" presidency and the omnipresence of politics

BY **JULIA HORNSTEIN**

ALTHOUGH BENJAMIN WITTEs never attended law school, he co-founded and is the editor-in-chief of Lawfare, a blog created in 2010 that discusses the influence of law on topics ranging from cyberspace to Presidential impeachment inquiries. Wittes is also a senior fellow at The Brookings Institution in the Governance Studies department. In addition to reporting for the Washington Post and the Legal Times, Wittes has also written several books, one of which, entitled Unmaking the Presidency: Donald Trump's War on the World's Most Powerful Office, will be released next month.

DID YOU GO TO LAW SCHOOL?

Nope, I'm a total fraud.

DO YOU THINK THAT BACKGROUND HELPS YOU PROVIDE A DIFFERENT TAKE ON LEGAL JOURNALISM?

Well, I think my job is to be as good a lawyer as the best lawyers. And to be as good a journalist as the best journalists. And I fail at both on a regular basis, but that is the job. What I think of as our role—our unique space—is to do legal scholarship and technical analysis at the speed of journalism.

WHAT MOTIVATED YOU TO START LAWFARE? WHAT'S YOUR FAVORITE PART OF THE JOB?

Lawfare started as a lark. It was really three friends who were writing together a lot: Robert Chesney, Jack Goldsmith, and me. We had sort of similar philosophical views on a variety of subjects and we wanted a place for kind of less formal more experimental writing.

We started Lawfare as a forum for our own writing. We certainly never imagined that it would take off the way it has taken off. I certainly never imagined it as becoming my job. It was just this little blog we did on the side of our other work. Honestly my favorite part of it has very little to do with my own writing: it is the role that it has been able to play in cultivating a civilized dialogue on very difficult issues from a genuinely ideologically diverse set of points of view.

DURING PRESIDENT TRUMP'S IMPEACHMENT HEARINGS, WHICH TESTIMONIES DID YOU FIND TO BE THE MOST HELPFUL IN CULTIVATING A PICTURE OF WHAT HAPPENED? WHICH WERE THE MOST JARRING?

Well, the most jarring is easy: that's Gordon Sondland, who nobody quite knew what to expect from given that he had given one testimony, kinda revised by letter, and now came in and very cheerfully made some very dramatic claims. So that is certainly the most jarring.

The most meaningful—moving—to me was Fiona Hill's, but that's because she's a longtime Brookings colleague of mine and we're acquainted and know each other in a way that makes the experience of watching somebody give testimony like that quite different. So I do think the most important testimonies are actually not the testimonies of the individuals; it's the accumulated account no one individual tells the whole story here the story starts with Masha Yovanovitch and continues through the Fiona Hills and Tim Morrisons and Taylors and George Kents and kind of finishes, but I do think it is actually important to see the whole picture of the aggregate story that all of the m are telling. Rather than [just looking at] Catherine Croft; rather than seeing one as the key witness.

FOLLOWING THE MORE FACTUAL LEGAL ELEMENTS OF THE HEARING, DO YOU VIEW THAT WHAT TRUMP DID—ESSENTIALLY EXCHANGING ACTIONS WITH UKRAINE IN ORDER TO GAIN POLITICAL BENEFIT, ESPECIALLY IN THE 2020 ELECTION—AS BRIBERY? OR DO YOU VIEW IT AS SOMETHING ELSE BASED ON THE FACTS PRESENTED IN THE TESTIMONIES?

BENJAMIN WITTES

I think the argument that you can cast what the president did as bribery is pretty good. That said, I'm not sure that the entirety of the issue is a bribery issue. One of the components is simply that its illegitimate to gin up fake investigations of your political opponents right and that's an abuse of power independent of whether it's accomplished by bribery or whether it's, you know, just asking him to do it. I could see formulating [a legal argument against Trump] in terms of an abuse of power; I could see formulating it in terms of bribery. Or both, to be honest.

THE LAW IS CLEARLY INFLUENCED BY THE POLITICS OF THE AGE. OBVIOUSLY YOU'VE DONE A TON OF WORK AND RESEARCH ON THE LAW, SO, IN THIS POLITICAL MOMENT, WHERE DO YOU THINK THE LAW IS GOING GIVEN THE IMPEACHMENT HEARINGS AND EVERYTHING THAT HAS BEEN HAPPENING?

Everybody's got a million things they would change in the law, and I'm no different from everyone else in that regard.

I don't think the fundamental problem is the law. I think the problem is you have a kind of "LOL, nothing matters" presidency and 40 to 45 percent of the population is content with that for whatever reason. I'm not enough of a political sociologist to assess the reasons why people don't actually seem to care, but enough people don't seem to care so that a kind of "LOL, nothing matters" presidency is not obviously self-destructive. And if you asked me five years ago: "if a president behaved this way, what's the remedy against that?" [I would have said] that you wouldn't survive two weeks: you'd get yourself impeached, have a collapse of political support, and that was the assumption. And that assumption turns out to be wrong at least for Donald Trump. That is a very threatening thing, and it's not a legal problem; its a political apathy problem.

SINCE THESE REMEDIES ARE STILL AVAILABLE, IS IT DIFFICULT FOR YOU TO WATCH THIS SENTIMENT OF "NOT CARING" THAT YOU WERE DESCRIBING AND HOW THAT'S ALMOST TRYING LAW IN A WAY?

Oh, I find it unfathomable. I don't spend my life getting angry about things, but I find myself very angry about this. Look, as a society, ultimately, everything is politics. Having good laws—having institutions that support and enforce those laws—ultimately has to be supported by a political layer that believes in those things. The tectonic layer that supports those institutions are the hearts and commitments of people at a political level. That's what prevents us from being any other society with elections and a corrupt use of power on top of those elections. Once you take away the commitment to that at the political level, the rest will fall apart.

"LOOK, AS A SOCIETY, ULTIMATELY, EVERYTHING IS POLITICS."

The Whitney and Betty MacMillan Center for International and Area Studies at Yale

YALE UNIVERSITY'S FOCAL POINT FOR PROMOTING TEACHING AND RESEARCH ON ALL ASPECTS OF INTERNATIONAL AFFAIRS, SOCIETIES, AND CULTURES AROUND THE WORLD



Academic & Research Programs

Six undergraduate majors: African Studies, East Asian Studies, Latin American and Iberian Studies, Modern Middle East Studies, Russian and East European Studies, and South Asian Studies.

Three master's degree programs: African Studies, East Asian Studies, and European and Russian Studies.

Four graduate certificates of concentration: African Studies, European Studies, Latin American and Iberian Studies, and Modern Middle East Studies.

Beyond the nine degree programs and other curricular contributions, the MacMillan Center has numerous interdisciplinary faculty councils, centers, and programs. These provide opportunities for scholarly research and intellectual innovation and encourage faculty and student interchange for undergraduates as well as graduate and professional students.

Grants & Fellowship Opportunities

An enduring commitment of the MacMillan Center is to enable students to spend time abroad to undertake research and other academically-oriented, international and area studies-related activities. Each year it supports Yale students with nearly $4 million in funding to pursue their research interests.

The MacMillan Center is also home to the Fox International Fellowship, a graduate student exchange program between Yale and 19 of the world's leading universities in Africa, Asia, Australia, Europe, the Middle East, and the Americas. Its goal is to enhance mutual understanding between the peoples of the United States and other countries by promoting international scholarly exchanges and collaborations among the next generation of leaders.

Special Events

The MacMillan Center extracurricular programs deepen and extend this research-teaching nexus of faculty and students at Yale, with more than 700 lectures, conferences, workshops, roundtables, symposia, film, and art events each year. Virtually all of these are open to the community at large. Its annual flagship lectures, the Coca-Cola World Fund Lecture and the George Herbert Walker, Jr. Lecture in International Studies, bring a number of prominent scholars and political figures to the Yale campus.

The MacMillan Report

The MacMillan Center produces *The MacMillan Report*, an Internet show that showcases Yale faculty in international and areas studies and their research in a one-on-one interview format. Webisodes can be viewed at macmillanreport.yale.edu.

YaleGlobal Online

This publication disseminates information about globalization to millions of readers in more than 215 countries around the world. *YaleGlobal* publishes original articles aimed at the wider public, authored by Yale faculty, world leaders, major foreign policy figures, and top specialists in politics, economics, diplomacy, business, health, and the environment.

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THE MACMILLAN CENTER IS HEADQUARTERED IN HENRY R. LUCE HALL, 34 HILLHOUSE AVENUE.